

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 822

Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1966

Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1966 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

Kingalu: A Myth of Origin from Eastern Tanzania

Ideally, Luguru marriage is: *a*) to a matrilateral cross cousin *b*) matri-local *c*) stable. I have shown elsewhere (1969) that the ideal and the real are often far apart in Luguru society, but that it is often *as though* they were realized. By this I mean that while not more than a third of marriages take place to a matrilateral cross-cousin, in the other cases it is usual for the "delayed right of bride removal" (RICHARDS 1950: 209) to take effect after the birth of a child, when a man moves to his own clan land, i. e., where his maternal uncle is living, so that he is now where he would have been if he had married the preferred partner. Although statistics of Luguru marriage show that it is far from stable if we consider the whole of the life of the partners, yet it *is* stable if we regard marriage largely as a means of producing and bringing up children to replace the previous generation. By this I mean that marriage is relatively stable for twenty years, but that after this time the likelihood of divorce, or separation, becomes increasingly probable, as hypothesized by MITCHELL (1961: 255–262).

[581
Basis Of Marriage](#)
[582
Regulation Of
Marriage](#)
[584
Arranging A Marriage](#)
[586
Termination Of
Marriage](#)
[591
Residence](#)
[851
Social Placement](#)

Both men and women have rights in land in Uluguru, and it is possible for a married couple to have land in at least four places, that is to say, in the clan areas of each parent of each partner, with the greatest claim in the clan areas of each of the partners.

[423
Real Property](#)
[591
Residence](#)
[613
Lineages](#)

Another aspect of the social structure, which must be mentioned is the question of *ugongo* (Luguru), *utani* (Swahili), a system of joking relationships between linked sub-clans which occurs all over the culture area and which has been discussed in some detail by CHRISTENSEN (1963) and BEIDELMAN (1969) (cf. RIGBY 1968). One reason cited for the origins of these relationships is that the groups concerned fought in the past but that neither achieved ascendancy. Another, and much more likely, reason, on the sub-clan level at least, is that intermarriage has brought this about. A point which BEIDELMAN does not appear to have considered is that we are presented with a hen/egg type of problem. *Utani* in Swahili means a joking relationship¹⁰, in which the partners are called *mtani*, plural *watani*. This relationship is called *ugongo* in Luguru, and the partners are termed *mgongo*, plural *wagongo*. But here the problem arises. The term for a cross-cousin in Luguru is *mtani*¹¹. Naturally many *watani* will  823 also be *wagongo*, and so we are left with the puzzle - are cross-cousins called *watani* because one behaves towards them in a joking fashion, or is the relationship referred to as *utani* between clans (and tribes) because one behaves as one would towards a cross-cousin?

113

[Bibliographies In Sources](#)

171

[Comparative Evidence](#)

601

[Kinship Terminology](#)

602

[Kin Relationships](#)

605

[Cousins](#)

613

[Lineages](#)

628

[Inter-Community Relations](#)

¹⁰ Cf. MOREAU 1948 and BEIDELMAN 1966 and 1967.

¹¹ As it is in a number of other Bantu-speaking peoples. We might also speculate on the meaning of *-gongo*, which in most Bantu languages has the meaning of a "spine", "ridge", or "back".

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)